

DESIGN

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ORIGINALLY A DESIGN was an artist's first sketch for a work of art; today, design plays a broader role in our lives. Before any object can be made, it must be designed. Most things around us have been designed to carry out a particular job. The design of objects is known as product design. There are also many other areas of design, such as fashion, garden, interior, and graphic design. Changing tastes can result in popular design movements, such as art nouveau and Bauhaus.

Product design

In order to design an object, the designer has several factors to consider. He or she must select a shape that suits the object's purpose but also consider other factors, such as the material to be used, the cost of manufacture, the safety and durability of the product, and how it will finally look. Product design usually aims to be both functional and stylish.

This bottle's shape is easily recognizable.



Coca-Cola bottle

A can's ringpull opening is designed to open easily.



Classic design

Some product designs so successfully combine functionality with a strong sense of style that they are timeless. The distinctive shape of the Coca-Cola bottle, for example, is a classic design that has hardly changed since 1915.



Classic cars

Some classic designs express certain ideals perfectly. The sleek lines of a sports-car's body, such as this MGB, are intended to suggest speed and freedom. Launched in 1962, the MGB became the best-selling single model sports car ever, with 512,000 owners worldwide.

The design process

The first stage in the design process is writing a design brief which details the functions and features to be achieved in the finished object. The designer then does a first sketch. This is translated into a rough model, or prototype, which is repeatedly tested and revised as needed. The design process of making numerous small amendments is called an iterative process. Finally, the actual product is made.



1 The designer does a first sketch on a drawing board or computer. This sketch shows a vacuum cleaner.



2 A series of prototypes is made out of different materials to test aspects of the design. The final prototype is handmade and painted to look identical to the final product.

3 The final product is made to the revised design brief. Designs can be patented (protected by copyright law) to prevent someone copying an original design.

Graphic design

Graphic designers use words and images to communicate a strong visual message. We are surrounded by graphic design, in magazines and books, on posters, on street signs. Designers use letters in different sizes and typefaces, often with colours and patterns, to make an impact.

London Underground map

The London Underground map is a brilliant piece of design. By distorting the distances between stations, it is possible to see the entire London Underground at a glance.



Shell Oil logo



Logos

Logos are graphic designs that aim to communicate a message without words. Companies design logos to be easily recognized by the public. The simple shape and strong colours of the logo shown above advertise the Shell Oil Company worldwide.

Computer-aided design

Increasingly, much of the design process is carried out on computer. Using computer-aided design, the designer creates a three-dimensional model, such as a car, on screen which can then be rotated and viewed from all angles.



Art Nouveau

Design movements are trends in design, some of which have a lasting influence. Art Nouveau was a design movement beginning in Europe in the 1880s that aimed to make ordinary objects, such as buildings, furniture, and jewellery, beautiful.



This Art Nouveau window in Paris, France, shows typical decorative curves based on organic forms.

Walter Gropius

In 1919, the German architect Walter Gropius (1883–1969) founded the Bauhaus design school. It taught the importance of functional design and of using materials such as steel, glass, and concrete. Bauhaus influenced the development of the arts. Gropius (on right) is shown with the French architect, Le Corbusier (1887–1965).



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